WinLayout User Guide

Version 1.17.6

Welcome to WinLayout

WinLayout remembers where you want your windows and keeps them there. It sits in the system tray and puts each window back where you left it: after a restart, when a monitor is plugged in or removed, or when an app opens a panel you had moved.

You tell WinLayout where a window belongs by capturing it, which creates a rule. From then on, whenever a matching window appears, WinLayout moves it to the rule's position, size and state. This guide covers installing, capturing windows, editing rules, locking windows in place and every setting.

What's new in version 1.17.6

- **Changed:** The "Report a problem" button in the About box now opens a problem report form in your web browser, with your WinLayout version already filled in, instead of opening the GitHub issues page.
- **New:** A "Request a feature" button in the About box, next to "Report a problem", opens a feature request form in your web browser, with your WinLayout version already filled in.
- **New:** An Appearance setting in App Settings: System, Light or Dark. System follows Windows' own light or dark setting, and now changes straight away when you switch Windows between light and dark. Before, a window that was already open kept its colours.
- **Improved:** The rules list no longer has grid lines. Rows are told apart by alternate shading, which looks the same in light and dark mode and fixes lines that came out bright or doubled, or disappeared when the pointer moved over the Apply, edit or delete buttons.
- **Improved:** The WinLayout name in the About box now matches the main window: the blue accent colour with a soft shadow.
- **Improved:** The name at the top of the main window is larger, in the blue accent colour with a soft shadow, and "by WinLayout-Apps" sits beside it in smaller grey text.
- **Improved:** The main window is now titled "WinLayout by WinLayout-Apps", and the About box shows "By WinLayout-Apps" under the name.
- **Improved:** The About box is narrower. The "Support me on Ko-fi" button now sits at the top right, level with the WinLayout name, with its right edge in line with the OK button, and "Report a problem" is at the bottom left.
- **Improved:** On the main window the About button has moved to the bottom right, the keyboard shortcut hints are on the left, and the rule counter is gone.
- **Improved:** In App Settings the troubleshooting log option is now last in the General list, and it says it should only be used when you have been asked to.
- **Improved:** The Capture All Open Windows confirmation now starts its warning about rules with "Caution:".

Installing and updating

Run the installer, WinLayout-Setup-<version>.exe. By default it installs just for you, so it doesn't ask for administrator rights, and you don't need to install .NET. WinLayout needs Windows 10 or 11, 64-bit.

Windows may show "Windows protected your PC" with an unknown publisher, because WinLayout isn't code-signed yet. Click **More info**, then **Run anyway**.

The installer offers two optional extras: starting WinLayout when you sign in to Windows, and a desktop shortcut. On the last page, leave **Launch WinLayout** ticked and press **Finish** to start it.

To update, run the newer installer over the old version. It offers to close the running copy, keeps your rules and settings, and shows a What's new screen the first time the new version opens.

Quick start

You can capture your first window and see it restored in four steps.

1. Put a window exactly where you want it, for example a File Explorer window on your second monitor.
2. In WinLayout, click **Capture Single Window**, then click **Start** in the box that appears.
3. Click the window you want to capture before the countdown ends. The countdown is 5 seconds unless you change it in App Settings.
4. WinLayout comes back to the front with a new rule in the list. Close the window and open it again: it returns to the saved place.

To save many windows at once, use **Capture All Open Windows** instead.

The main window

The main window has a toolbar across the top, your list of rules in the middle and a footer at the bottom. Closing the window doesn't quit WinLayout: it keeps running in the system tray.

Toolbar button	What it does
Capture All Open Windows	Saves the position of every open window that isn't minimised.
Capture Single Window	Saves one window of your choice after a short countdown.
About	In the bottom right of the window. Shows the version and copyright, a Check for updates link, and Support me on Ko-fi, Report a problem and Request a feature buttons.
App Settings	Opens the settings for shortcuts, start-up, notifications and more.
Reorder Rules	Lets you drag rules into a new order.

Each row in the list is one rule.

Column	Meaning
Apply (button, far left)	Moves the matching open windows to the rule's position now.
Enabled	Tick to switch the rule on. Untick to switch it off.
Rule Name	A label for the rule.
Application	The program the rule is for, for example chrome.
Window	Main window, or Floating (undocked) for panels.
Title Contains (optional)	Text the window's title must contain.
Monitor	Which monitor the position is measured from.
X, Y	The window's top-left corner.
Width, Height	The window's size.
State	Normal or Maximized.
Cog and x (far right)	The cog edits the rule. The x deletes it, after asking you to confirm.

The footer lists the keyboard shortcuts that are switched on, and has the About button on the right.

Capturing windows

Capturing a window records where it is now and saves that as a rule. There are three ways to do it.

Capture Single Window saves one window. Click it, read the box, then click **Start**. Switch to the window you want before the countdown reaches zero, and that window is captured. WinLayout then returns to the front. Press **Cancel** to stop. If the box says it couldn't capture the window, you probably didn't switch to your target in time, or the window has no title text.

Capture All Open Windows saves every open window that isn't minimised, with one rule per program. WinLayout asks you to confirm first, with a caution that rules are added and updated. Programs that already have a rule keep it, and its position is updated.

Save active window is a keyboard shortcut that captures whichever window is in front, with no countdown. It is switched off until you turn it on in App Settings.

When you capture a window that an existing rule already covers, WinLayout updates that rule instead of adding a second one.

Working with rules

WinLayout applies a rule by itself when a matching window appears, and again a moment later for apps that move their own windows. Windows that were already open when WinLayout started are only positioned for rules with Lock ticked. Use the **Apply** button for the rest.

In the list you can do four things without opening the editor:

- Press **Apply** to move the matching windows now.
- Tick **Enabled** to switch a rule on and apply it. Untick it to switch the rule off.
- Click the **cog** to edit the rule. Double-clicking a row, or pressing Enter, does the same.
- Click the **x** to delete the rule. WinLayout asks you to confirm.

The edit window holds every setting of a rule:

Setting	What it does
Rule Name	A label for the rule.
Application	The program's name, for example chrome. Leave it empty to match any program.
Window	Main window for the app's normal windows, or Floating (undocked) for panels.
Title Contains (optional)	Text the window's title must contain. Tick **Treat as a regular expression** for pattern matching.
Monitor	Which monitor the position is measured from.
State	Normal, or Maximized. A maximized rule ignores position and size, which are greyed out.
Position and Size	X, Y, Width and Height, in pixels.
Lock	Snaps the window back if it is moved or resized.

Save applies your changes and applies the rule to matching windows straight away. **Save as New Rule** keeps the original rule and adds a copy with the settings on the page. **Delete rule** removes the rule after asking you to confirm. A rule needs an Application or some Title text, otherwise it couldn't match anything.

Each window follows one rule. A rule with Title Contains text beats a rule for the whole application. If two rules are equally specific, the one higher in the list wins, and switched-off rules are skipped.

Reordering rules

The order of the list only matters when two rules cover the same window equally specifically: the rule higher in the list is used.

To change the order:

1. Click **Reorder Rules**. The button turns pale blue, and everything else is greyed out and can't be clicked.
2. Drag a rule up or down. A blue line shows where it will land when you let go.
3. Click **Reorder Rules** again to finish. The new order is saved as you go.

If the list is long, hold a rule near the top or bottom edge to scroll.

Lock: keeping a window in place

Tick **Lock** in a rule's edit window and its windows snap straight back to the saved place whenever they are moved, resized, maximized or restored.

Lock is gentle by design:

- It waits until you let go of the mouse, so it never fights you mid-drag.
- It leaves minimising alone.
- It lets go for 30 seconds if a window refuses to take the saved size, instead of fighting it.
- It stops watching a window as soon as the window is hidden or closed.

To move a locked window on purpose, pause locking first: use **Pause window locking** in the tray menu, or the pause shortcut if you have turned it on. Move the window, capture it again so the rule learns the new place, then resume locking.

Undocked (floating) windows

Many apps let you pull a panel, such as an image browser, out of the main window so it floats on its own. WinLayout treats these as a separate kind of window, shown as **Floating (undocked)** in the Window column, so a panel never gets the main window's position.

To save a panel's position, undock it, put it where you want it, then use **Capture Single Window** and switch to the panel before the countdown ends. The rule is matched by the panel's title, so its Title Contains text is filled in for you.

Floating rules follow a few extra safeguards:

- They only apply once the app's main window is showing and not minimised. Apps hide their panels while the main window is minimised.
- A window that appears before the main window, such as a splash screen, is ignored.
- WinLayout never re-shows a panel the app has hidden, for example one you have just docked back in.
- If you press **Apply** on a floating rule and nothing moves, WinLayout tells you why: the app isn't open, its main window is minimised, or no undocked window matches.

Using several monitors

WinLayout remembers which monitor a window was on. X and Y are measured from the top-left corner of that monitor's usable area, the part not covered by the taskbar, so a window stays on the right screen even if you rearrange your displays.

The **Monitor** setting in a rule's edit window has three kinds of choice:

- A specific monitor, listed with its size, for example "Primary · DISPLAY1 (2560×1440)".
- **Spans multiple monitors**, for windows stretched across screens. WinLayout picks this itself when you capture a window that covers two or more monitors. It restores the exact position, as long as your monitors are still arranged the same way.
- **Any (absolute coordinates)**, which ignores which monitor is which.

If a rule's monitor isn't connected, its window goes to the primary monitor and is kept fully on screen. The rule keeps its settings and is marked "(disconnected)", so it works again when the monitor returns.

App Settings

Click **App Settings** in the toolbar to change how WinLayout behaves everywhere, not just for one rule. Press **Save** to keep your changes or **Cancel** to leave them.

Keyboard shortcuts. All four shortcuts are off by default. Each has a tick box to switch it on, a box where you click and then press the new keys, and a Reset button for the suggested keys. A shortcut must include Ctrl, Alt or Shift. WinLayout stops you using the same keys twice, and tells you if another program already uses a combination.

Shortcut	What it does	Suggested keys
Save active window	Captures the window that is in front.	Ctrl+Alt+S
Capture All Open Windows	Captures every open window that isn't minimised.	Ctrl+Alt+A
Apply all rules	Applies every rule to the open windows.	Ctrl+Alt+R
Pause / resume locking	Stops or restarts locked windows snapping back.	Ctrl+Alt+P

The shortcuts you have switched on are listed at the bottom of the main window and in the tray menu. If they are all off, the bottom line says so.

General.

- **Start WinLayout when I sign in to Windows** starts it quietly in the tray at sign-in.
- **Appearance** switches WinLayout between Light, Dark and System. System, the default, follows Windows' own light or dark setting and changes with it. The change applies straight away.
- **Show notifications** turns on the small tray messages. They are off by default.
- **Check for updates automatically** asks GitHub whether a newer version exists, when WinLayout starts and every few hours. It is on by default.
- **Capture Single Window counts down for** sets the countdown, from 1 to 60 seconds.
- **Write a troubleshooting log (Use only when instructed to do so)** records what WinLayout does to windows in `%AppData%\WinLayout\trace.log`. It is off by default. The log includes window titles, so look through it before sharing it.

Uninstall WinLayout is the red button at the bottom left. It asks you to confirm, and then asks whether to keep your saved rules.

The tray icon and starting WinLayout

WinLayout lives in the system tray, near the clock. Windows sometimes tucks tray icons behind the small arrow; drag the WinLayout icon out to keep it visible.

Double-click the icon to open the main window. Right-click it for the menu:

Menu item	What it does
Rules…	Opens the main window.
Apply rules now	Applies every rule to the open windows.
Save active window	Captures the window that is in front.
Capture All Open Windows	Captures every open window that isn't minimised, after asking you to confirm.
Pause window locking	Stops locked windows snapping back until you untick it.
Start with Windows	Switches start-at-sign-in on or off.
Exit	Closes WinLayout completely.

When you start WinLayout from the Start menu or a shortcut, the main window opens. If it is already running in the tray, the same click brings its window to the front instead of starting a second copy. When Windows starts WinLayout at sign-in, it stays quietly in the tray and the window doesn't open.

Troubleshooting

Most problems come down to a rule that matches more, or less, than you expect. Press **Apply** on the rule to test it quickly.

Problem	What to try
A window doesn't move	Check that the rule's Enabled box is ticked, the Application matches the program's name, and any Title Contains text really appears in the window's title.
A window of an elevated (administrator) program won't move	Windows only lets an elevated program's windows be moved by another elevated program. Run WinLayout as administrator.
Other windows of the same program move too	A rule with only an Application covers every window of that program. Add Title Contains text to narrow it.
A window snaps back when I try to move it	Lock is ticked. Pause locking, or untick Lock in the rule.
An undocked panel isn't placed	The app's main window must be showing and not minimised, and the rule's Window must be Floating (undocked). Press Apply to see why.
A window opens on the wrong monitor	Check the rule's Monitor. If that monitor is disconnected, the window goes to the primary one.
A keyboard shortcut does nothing	Shortcuts are off until you switch them on in App Settings. Another program may also be using those keys.
Windows warns about an unknown publisher	WinLayout isn't code-signed yet. Click More info, then Run anyway. Some antivirus programs also flag new unsigned programs by mistake.
The old icon still shows after updating	Windows keeps icons in a cache. Restart File Explorer, or sign out and back in.

If you still need help, open an issue on GitHub (see Getting help and supporting WinLayout). If you are asked for a troubleshooting log, switch on **Write a troubleshooting log** in App Settings, repeat the problem, and

attach the log to the issue.

Your data, updating and uninstalling

Everything stays on your PC, and WinLayout doesn't collect any data about you. Its only network use is a check on GitHub for a newer version, when it starts and every few hours, and you can switch that off in App Settings. Links such as the Ko-fi page open in your browser only when you click them.

Its files are in `%AppData%\WinLayout`:

File	What it holds
rules.json	Your rules
settings.json	Your App Settings
error.log	Any unexpected error
trace.log	The troubleshooting log, only if you switched it on

The start-with-Windows setting is a standard start-up entry for your Windows user, and WinLayout removes it when you uninstall.

Updating. WinLayout checks GitHub for a newer version when it starts and every few hours. You can switch this off with Check for updates automatically in App Settings, or check by hand with the Check for updates link in the About box. When a newer version is out, a message appears once in the tray, and Version x is available shows at the top of the tray menu. Either takes you to the download page. WinLayout never installs anything by itself. To update, run the newer installer over the old one. Your rules and settings are kept.

Uninstalling. Use **Settings, Apps** in Windows, or **App Settings, Uninstall WinLayout**. WinLayout closes, is removed, and asks whether to delete your saved rules. If you keep them, they are there when you reinstall.

Getting help and supporting WinLayout

Questions and problem reports go to GitHub Issues. Open a new issue, say what you were doing when the problem happened, and include your WinLayout version, which is shown in the About box. You need a free GitHub account to open an issue. If you are asked for a troubleshooting log, attach the one described above. The About box also has a Report a problem button, which opens a problem report form in your web browser, with your WinLayout version already filled in. Next to it, Request a feature opens a form for suggestions.

You can also contact me through Ko-fi, but only once you have supported WinLayout: Ko-fi only allows direct messages after a payment. Leave a message with your tip, or write to me from your Ko-fi Messages afterwards. For anything else, use GitHub Issues.

WinLayout is made in spare time. If it saves you some fiddling, you can support it with the **Support me on Ko-fi** button in the About box, or at ko-fi.com/C3M629R9XJ. The money goes towards a code-signing certificate, so Windows stops showing the unknown-publisher warning.